

and dying for treatment. "At first, they came in a trickle and it took more than two years before they developed faith in the medicine and care that we offered," recalls Prakash. He sensed that apart from improving their health status, it was equally important to give the Gond children an opportunity of education in order to rescue them from their primitive condition. He opened an ashram school and with the help of the tribal children, introduced the parents to settled agriculture—growing vegetables, fruits and grains. He also taught them the value of conservation and protection of forests and wild animals. For this, he created a mini zoo to educate them about the need to live in harmony with nature.

Prakash believes education has also helped dispel superstitious beliefs and made them conscious of their rights. "All this involved a longer learning curve, given the lack of exposure and attitude of the Madia Gonds to comprehend the long-term good," explains Prakash. His patience has paid off and over the years shown striking results. This has pushed up

their literacy rate from zero to 25 per cent in three decades among the 2,00,000 residing in the area. The ashram school has become a boarding school with 700 students. It has encouraged two—Pandu Pungati and Kanna Dobi—to become medical graduates while others have become lawyers.

Now, at the 50-bed hospital, five doctors treat 40,000 patients a year for free. Annually, medical specialists

Their humanitarian work among poor illiterate tribals has earned them the title of "the Albert Schweitzer couple of India".

come from Nagpur to run a camp at the hospital where more than 150 surgeries are performed. Equally gratifying for them is the involvement of their children. While Dighant, 32, a medical graduate, and his wife Anagha, take a mobile clinic around the Gond habitations six days a week, the second son Aniket, 30, a mechanical engineer, helps the Gond youth at a vocational training centre. "For us the challenge is not one of making

sacrifices like our grandparents and parents but continuing the work initiated by them," says Dighant.

The Amtes are a moral influence on the Gonds and even settle their marital disputes but it's been tough seeing the project through to its current level and it still is. The Amtes begin their day at five in the morning and finish at 10 p.m.. "It is a legacy that continues and needs to be replicated in other tribal tracts, where the people are still deprived of health and education," says Prakash. Talking about the Ramon Magsaysay award he will receive shortly at the end of August, he says: "This prize saves a lot of effort in highlighting the needs of the tribals, motivates the youth and brings all these to public knowledge." It's not their first either. In 1995, the couple were honoured by the Principality of Monaco, which released a stamp featuring them to commemorate another famous humanitarian, Albert Schweitzer. The Amtes were described as "the Schweitzer couple of India". Now, sharing a prize with Baba Amte, they are doubly honoured. **with A. Rammohan Rao**

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